

FREE RESOURCE · COACHING

Powerful Questions Bank

60 Questions

A bank of 60 powerful coaching questions organised by purpose — opening, exploring, reframing, challenging, and commitment — with follow-up question prompts.

60 Questions

5 Purpose Categories

When to Use Each Type

Follow-Up Prompts

60

questions

5

categories

12

per category

12

follow-up prompts

HOW TO USE THIS BANK

These five categories loosely follow the arc of a coaching conversation, but real conversations rarely move in a straight line — you might reframe before you've fully explored, or challenge before you reframe. Choose the question that fits where the person actually is, not where the category order says they should be.

Opening

Building rapport and setting the agenda for the conversation.

12 questions

1. What would make this conversation genuinely useful for you today?
2. What's the real topic you want to explore, underneath what you just said?
3. Where would you like to start?
4. What's been on your mind since we last spoke?
5. What's the most important thing for us to cover today?
6. On a scale of 1–10, how are you feeling about where things stand right now?
7. What would you like to be different by the end of this conversation?
8. What's changed since the last time we talked about this?
9. What brought this to the top of your list today?
10. If this conversation goes well, what will have happened?
11. What haven't you said yet that you probably should?
12. What's really going on for you right now?

Exploring

Deepening understanding of the situation before moving to solutions.

12 questions

13. What does this situation actually look like, in detail?
14. What have you already tried?

- 15. What's the impact of this on you, and on others?
- 16. What assumptions are you making here?
- 17. Who else is involved, and how do they see this?
- 18. What's the story you're telling yourself about this?
- 19. What's within your control here, and what isn't?

- 20. What haven't you considered yet?
- 21. What would someone outside this situation notice?
- 22. How long has this been building?
- 23. What's the piece of this that's hardest to talk about?
- 24. What emotions come up when you think about this?

Reframing

Shifting perspective and testing the assumptions underneath the situation.

12 questions

- 25. What's another way to look at this?
- 26. What would this look like if it weren't a problem, but an opportunity?
- 27. What's the opposite of what you're assuming right now?
- 28. If a friend described this exact situation, what would you tell them?
- 29. What might this situation be teaching you?
- 30. What's one thing that's actually going right here?
- 31. How might you see this differently in six months?
- 32. What would it mean to let go of needing to be right here?
- 33. What's the most generous interpretation of what happened?
- 34. If this weren't about you, what would you notice?
- 35. What's a completely different way to frame this goal?
- 36. What would change if you assumed the best about the other person?

Challenging

Pushing past comfort zone and naming what's being avoided.

12 questions

- 37. What are you avoiding by focusing on this instead?
- 38. What would you do if you weren't afraid?
- 39. What's the real reason you haven't already acted?
- 40. What's the cost of staying exactly where you are?
- 41. Whose approval are you actually seeking here?
- 42. What would the bravest version of you do next?
- 43. What are you protecting by not changing this?
- 44. What's the belief that's holding you back, and is it actually true?
- 45. If failure weren't possible, what would you attempt?
- 46. What's the hardest truth you're avoiding right now?
- 47. What would you need to give up to get what you say you want?
- 48. Who do you need to become to make this happen?

Commitment

Converting insight into a specific, owned next step.

12 questions

- 49. What's the very next step, specifically?
- 50. By when will you do this?
- 51. How will you know you've succeeded?
- 52. What might get in the way, and how will you handle it?
- 53. What support do you need, and from whom?
- 54. How committed are you to this, from 1–10?
- 55. What would make you abandon this plan?
- 56. Who will you tell about this commitment?
- 57. What's the smallest version of this you could start today?
- 58. How will you hold yourself accountable?
- 59. What do you want to have done by our next conversation?
- 60. What's one thing you're taking away from today?

Follow-Up Question Prompts

A powerful opening question is only the start. These short, universal prompts work after almost any question above to invite more depth without redirecting the conversation.

- “ Tell me more about that.*
- “ What else?*
- “ Say more about that.*
- “ What makes you say that?*
- “ How so?*
- “ What's underneath that?*
- “ And what else is true?*
- “ What's the feeling behind that?*
- “ Can you give me an example?*
- “ What do you mean by that, exactly?*
- “ What's the short version of that?*
- “ Is there more?*

THE REAL SKILL

The best coaches use far fewer questions than this bank contains — not because they've memorised more, but because they've listened closely enough to know which one question, right now, will actually open something up. Use this bank to build range, then let the moment decide.